



Where Our IT Students Went

— and Where the Next Ones Are Coming
From

Position brief — group meeting on IT cohorts and Services Québec IT
courses

July 2026 · Every figure verifiable from public sources (cited per slide)

Agenda — Five Questions, One Answer



- 1 What actually happened to our enrollment? (It was policy, not the market.)
- 2 Why did the domestic career-entry student hesitate too?
- 3 Where did the demand go? (It changed shape — it didn't shrink.)
- 4 What do we do about it? Five moves, zero new funding.
- 5 Why acting now beats waiting for the caps to lift.

The Short Version (1/2) — What Happened



Two levers were pulled out from under us at the same time:

Lever 1 — The international pipeline

Cut off by federal and provincial policy decrees. Study permits, CAQ quotas, PGWP and PEQ pathways — all restricted, all at once, all deliberately.

Lever 2 — The career-entry student

Stopped believing a one- or two-year IT program is a safe bet in the age of AI — and the entry-level hiring data gave that fear a real foundation.

The Short Version (2/2) — The Claim



“Montréal did not stop needing IT skills.

Our intake pipeline was closed by decree, and our product format no longer matches what the market buys.”

Neither problem fixes itself. Both are fixable this fall — by changing what we sell and who we sell it to, with the instructors, labs and material we already have.

The Pipeline Was Closed on Purpose (1/3) — Federal



≈75,000

new study permits approved in Canada in
2025 — below the 2020 COVID floor

−64%

year-over-year drop in new permit approvals
(2024 → 2025)

155,000

the 2026 cap on new arrivals — about half the
2025 target

- **The 2026–2028 Immigration Levels Plan holds new arrivals at 150,000 per year through 2028.**
- Refusal rates hit 60–70% in peak months; approval rates for college programs sat near 25%.
- **This is not a market cycle. It is a standing federal policy with a fixed multi-year horizon.**

Source: IRCC data via ICEF Monitor (Apr. 2026); ApplyBoard ApplyInsights (Oct. 2025); Budget 2025 Immigration Levels Plan.

The Pipeline Was Closed on Purpose (2/3) — Colleges



–42%

international enrollment at Canadian colleges, 2023-24 →
2025-26

–75%

collapse in NEW college cohorts over the same two years

- New college cohort sizes are back to 2020-21 levels — a full decade of growth erased.
- Universities took –17%; colleges absorbed the deepest cuts — exactly our segment.
- Québec fared “best” among provinces at –14% overall — but the college-level programs still took the hit.

Source: Statistics Canada preliminary enrollment estimates, released May 2026.

The Pipeline Was Closed on Purpose (3/3) — Québec



- PL 74 decree (Feb. 2025): CAQ applications capped at 124,760 — a 20% cut — with quotas set per institution and per credential type.
- **AECs were explicitly targeted: the Minister of Higher Education called them «voies rapides» to permanent residency and said she wanted to cut them further.**
- MIFI 2026–2029 plan: maximum 106,400 study-permit holders in 2026, down from 128,090 in 2024; institutional quotas locked to December 2027.
- No new tuition-fee exemptions for priority-field programs as of Fall 2026; the PEQ pathway that made our programs attractive is gone.
- **Bottom line: the students who filled our AEC and Services Québec IT cohorts were removed by decree — through at least the end of 2027.**

Source: MIFI decree under PL 74 (Feb. 2025); Radio-Canada; Le Devoir; MIFI Planification pluriannuelle 2026–2029; Gouvernement du Québec.

What This Means for Us



“Let’s improve our marketing” is not an answer to a policy decree.

Waiting this out is not a strategy — it’s a slow program closure.

The good news: the replacement market is domestic, funded, and already standing outside our door.

The Domestic Student Hesitates (1/2) — The Fear



-13%

relative employment decline since late 2022,
ages 22–25, in the most AI-exposed
occupations

6–7%

unemployment among recent CS / computer-
engineering graduates (US)

-30%

tech internship postings since 2023, while
applications rose

- Stanford Digital Economy Lab (Brynjolfsson et al., Aug. 2025), built on ADP payroll data covering millions of workers.
- Software development and IT support are on the most-exposed list. Our prospective students read the same headlines we do.
- A 19-year-old weighing a career-entry IT program in 2026 hesitates — and our enrollment reflects that hesitation.**

Source: Brynjolfsson, Chandar & Chen, “Canaries in the Coal Mine” (Aug. 2025); NY Fed College Labor Market data; Handshake.



The Domestic Student Hesitates (2/2) — The Half Nobody Quotes

+6–9%

employment GROWTH, ages 35–49, in the SAME AI-exposed occupations

Growing

entry-level employment in roles where AI augments the work instead of replacing it

- The market is not rejecting IT skills.
- It is rejecting inexperience without AI fluency — and rewarding experienced people who retool.
- That means the growing buyer is the career-changer and the upskiller, not the career-starter.

Source: Same Stanford/ADP study — augmentation vs. automation split, and 35–49 age-band results.

Demand Changed Shape (1/2) — Skills Over Headcount



95%

of cybersecurity teams report at least one skills gap

59%

call those gaps critical or significant — up from 44% in 2024

≈70%

of professionals are pursuing AI-related qualifications

- The 2025 ISC2 Workforce Study (16,029 professionals) stopped publishing a headcount gap for the first time — because the binding constraint is now specific skills, not bodies.
- AI security and cloud security top the demand list.
- That is a demand profile for short, targeted, stackable training — not multi-semester career-entry cohorts.**

Source: 2025 ISC2 Cybersecurity Workforce Study (Dec. 2025).

Demand Changed Shape (2/2) — Defence Money Arrived



\$81.8B

committed to the Canadian Armed Forces
build-out by 2030

125,000

jobs projected under Canada's first Defence
Industrial Strategy (Feb. 2026)

\$4.5M

for a single cyber-range lab in Québec (UQO,
Mar. 2026) under the RDII

- Cybersecurity, AI and quantum are named priority technologies in the Strategy.
- The revised ITB policy adds a multiplier rewarding primes that invest in skills training — defence contractors now have a concrete incentive to fund courses like ours.
- Our six accepted Services Québec defence-sector courses were in place before this wave crested. We are early — the only good time to be.**

Source: "Security, Sovereignty and Prosperity" — Canada Defence Industrial Strategy (Feb. 17, 2026); CED / RDII announcements (Mar. 2026).

The Plan — Five Moves, Zero New Funding



- 1 Shift the centre of gravity to short PD modules (15–45 h)
- 2 Sell cohorts to employers, not only seats to individuals
- 3 Make “IT with AI” the explicit product in every course
- 4 Lead with hands-on labs — the moat MOOCs can’t copy
- 5 Run inter-college PD partnerships instead of competing

None of these requires new money — they redirect effort we already spend.

Move 1 — Short, Stackable Modules (15–45 h)



- **Keep the AEC as the destination — stop treating it as the front door.**
- Short courses become the front door: one 30-hour module → a result at work → the next module → the sequence ladders into the AEC.
- Matches what the skills data says the market buys (ISC2: skills over headcount).
- Matches what Services Québec funds: requalification of the Québec workforce — workers 30+, career-changers, PR holders needing local credentials.
- **That demographic is the one the employment data shows growing.**

Move 2 — Sell Cohorts to Employers



- **One defence-supply-chain SME with twelve employees needing incident-response basics = a full cohort in a single phone call.**
- The ITB skills-training multiplier gives primes a concrete reason to sponsor supplier training.
- Aerospace, logistics and municipal IT in greater Montréal are the same play.
- Group-training agreements smooth out the minimum-enrollment problem that keeps killing our course launches.

Move 3 — “IT with AI” as the Explicit Product



- **The data splits the market: automated roles (shrinking) vs. augmented roles (growing). We train only for the second kind.**
- Every module pairs a classic competency — networking, hardening, log analysis, scripting — with the AI-assisted workflow a professional actually uses in 2026.
- It is also our honest answer to the hesitant 19-year-old: we’re not pretending AI away — we’re teaching you to be the person it can’t replace.

Move 4 — Hands-On Labs Are the Moat



- **Real infrastructure, real topologies, real incidents — bilingual delivery.**
- Local virtualization, the CyberQuébec range, and cloud sandboxes: capacity YouTube and the MOOCs cannot sell.
- Put the lab experience on page one of every course description — not buried in the syllabus.

Move 5 — Inter-College PD Partnerships



- **Concrete planning session already held with John Abbott (June 25) on jointly offering IT professional-development courses.**
- Shared catalogue: Core IT, cybersecurity, DevOps/IaC, applied AI, and the human-factors track.
- Shared marketing and shared cohorts across institutions solve the class-size math none of us can solve alone anymore.
- **Ask of this group: a mandate to formalize that model.**

“Why Not Wait for the Caps to Lift?”



- Federal plan: 150,000 new arrivals per year, locked through 2028.
- Québec institutional quotas: fixed to December 2027.
- PEQ pathway: gone. New tuition exemptions: none from Fall 2026.
- Best case, rebuilding the international pipeline is a 2029 conversation.**
- Meanwhile the requalification market — domestic, funded, growing — is here now, and we can serve it with the instructors, labs and material we already have.**



Fewer long runways. More short flights.

Same destination, same standards, same labs — packaged the way 2026 actually buys training.

Sources (1/2) — Enrollment & Policy



- IRCC study-permit approvals, reported by ICEF Monitor (Apr. 2026) and ApplyBoard ApplyInsights (Oct. 2025).
- Statistics Canada — preliminary international enrollment estimates, 2024-25 and 2025-26 (May 2026).
- Government of Canada — 2026–2028 Immigration Levels Plan (Budget 2025).
- MIFI — decree of Feb. 26, 2025 under PL 74; Planification pluriannuelle de l’immigration 2026–2029.
- Radio-Canada and Le Devoir coverage of the CAQ quotas and AEC restrictions (2025–2026).
- Gouvernement du Québec — tuition-fee exemption program notice (no new exemptions from Fall 2026).

Sources (2/2) — Labour Market & Defence



- Brynjolfsson, Chandar & Chen — “Canaries in the Coal Mine,” Stanford Digital Economy Lab, ADP payroll data (Aug. 2025).
- NY Fed — College Labor Market data; Handshake internship-postings data.
- 2025 ISC2 Cybersecurity Workforce Study — 16,029 respondents (Dec. 2025).
- “Security, Sovereignty and Prosperity” — Canada’s Defence Industrial Strategy (Feb. 17, 2026).
- CED — Regional Defence Investment Initiative announcements, incl. UQO cyber-range funding (Mar. 2026).

Questions welcome — every number above survives a fact-check.